

NECK PAIN

Give urgent attention to the patient with neck pain and any of:

- Neck stiffness and any of: temperature $\geq 38^{\circ}\text{C}$, headache, drowsy/confused or purple/red rash: **meningitis** likely. Give **ceftriaxone** 2g IV¹/IM. Avoid injecting > 1g IM at one injection site.
- Neurological symptoms in arms/legs: weakness, numbness, clumsiness, stiffness, change in gait or difficulty with co-ordination
- Recent injury and x-ray unavailable/abnormal or neurological symptoms: apply rigid neck collar and immobilise head with tape and sandbags/IV fluid bags on either side of head.

Refer urgently.

Approach to the patient with neck pain not needing urgent attention

Any of: >50 years, pain progressive or lasting > 6 weeks, oral steroid use, HIV, diabetes, IV drug use, unexplained weight loss/fever or TB/neck surgery/previous cancer?

Yes

- Do cervical spine x-ray.
- Check CRP.
- Discuss with specialist.

No

- Give **paracetamol** 1g 4-6 hourly (up to 4g in 24 hours) for up to 5 days. If no response, give **ibuprofen**² 400mg 8 hourly with food for up to 5 days.
- If no better after 5 days and no arm pain, refer for physiotherapy. If pain ≥ 4 weeks, assess and advise **61**.
- If no response after 6 weeks, arm pain, weakness/numbness develops or pain worsens, do cervical spine x-rays and refer.

ARM OR HAND SYMPTOMS

- Check joints and ask patient to place hands behind head, then behind back. Bury nails in palm and open hand. Press palms together with elbows lifted. Walk. Sit and stand up with arms folded.
- If joint warm/tender/swollen or unable to do all actions comfortably, **joint problem** likely **62**.

Give urgent attention to the patient with arm or hand symptoms and any of:

- Arm pain with chest pain **37**.
- If recent injury and severe pain/swelling or deformity, **fracture** likely **18**.
- New sudden onset of weakness of arm with/without difficulty speaking or visual disturbance: consider stroke or TIA **136**.

Approach to the patient with arm or hand symptoms not needing urgent attention

Painful shoulder

Referred pain likely

Ask about neck pain (see above), cough/difficulty breathing **38**, chest pain **37**, abdominal pain **44**, pregnancy **157**.

Wrist/hand pain: intermittent, worse at night, relieved by shaking. May be numbness/tingling in 1st, 2nd and 3rd fingers or weakness of hand.

Carpal tunnel syndrome likely

Splint wrist in neutral position at night.

Elbow pain with or after elbow flexion/extension. May have decreased grip strength.

Tennis or golfer's elbow likely

- Advise patient to apply ice to elbow and rest arm.
- Give **ibuprofen**² 400mg 8 hourly with food for 10 days.
- Refer for physiotherapy.

Pain at base of thumb worsened by thumb or wrist movement or catching/locking of finger

Tenosynovitis of hand/wrist likely

- Rest and splint joint.
- Give **ibuprofen**² 400mg 8 hourly with food for up to 5 days.

If no better after 6 weeks or worsens, refer to doctor.

¹Do not mix Ringer's lactate and IV ceftriaxone. Flush IV line with **sodium chloride 0.9%** before and after IV ceftriaxone. ²Avoid if peptic ulcer, asthma, hypertension, heart failure or kidney disease. If patient also taking aspirin, advise to wait at least 30 minutes after taking aspirin before taking ibuprofen.